

Remembering the lives of those in Illinois who died from coronavirus

They were mothers and fathers, daughters and sons. Many were proud grandparents. Two were sisters from a tight-knit South Side family. All were loved, relatives say, and will be forever missed. As the number of deaths attributable to the coronavirus ticks upward, the Tribune is working to chronicle those who have lost their lives in the Chicago area or who have connections to our region. These are some of those victims.

PEGGY RAKESTRAW, 72

From Matteson. Died March 25.



FAMILY PHOTO

Peggy Rakestraw had high standards for her two daughters.

Her youngest, Jennifer, said her mother was strict but loving. She often reminded her daughters to make sure they saved their money "for a rainy day" and to be independent.

"She was protective and wanted the best for us," her

daughter said. "When she said something, she meant it and everyone knew it."

The 72-year-old Matteson woman died March 25 in a south suburban hospital. Though she long had been in failing health due to end-stage kidney disease that required dialysis three times a week, her daughter said the family is stunned by her sudden death and left with

conditions, including diabetes, which were listed as contributing factors.

Family and friends described his larger-than-life personality and passion for competitive sports, both as a participant and a spectator. He was a popular competitive darts player on the city's Northwest Side who also loved attending live concerts, outdoor festivals, skiing and travel.

A close friend, Peter Citera, remembered Elton for his "his easy smile, infectious laughter and unparalleled love of life."

"The two things that made Alvin happiest were sports and having a cold beer with good friends," Citera said in an online tribute. "If the two could be combined — as they often were — well, that was absolutely ideal."

Elton graduated Evanston Township High School, later following in his father's footsteps while pursuing a career as a pipefitter, his wife said.

She said they met nearly 20 years ago while on opposing teams during a Thursday night Windy City Darters league match at a Rogers Park bar. She isn't positive

Her co-worker Char Oliver remembered Ciametti as a hard worker who put her family first, and as someone whose skills elicited deep loyalty in her clients.

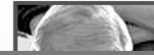
"She would have people come in from other establishments that couldn't (handle) their dogs," she said. "A lot of these dogs had problems, but she got them done. For that her clients were absolutely grateful."

Aside from Jones, Ciametti is survived by her son Michael and daughter, Vanessa; and grandchildren Cheyenne, Christopher, Steven and Paulie.

— John Keilman

JOHN 'CURT' JOHNSON, 93

Professor emeritus, Evanston. Died March 22.



In his 93 years, John "Curt" Johnson was fueled by a passion for reading, teaching and an

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